

Capstone: Plan, Build & Present a Portfolio Piece

The single end-of-course assessment (Module 7). Each learner chooses one brief, plans it, builds it in an organized, non-destructive file, and presents it with a short statement and an honest critique. Score it with the rubric below; completion requires a delivered export and a saved layered master.

Covers Modules 0-7

Brief chosen in Session 7 · presented in Session 8

Pass: 2+ on every scored row

THE BRIEF

Choose **one** brief from the list below (the same six options as Lesson 20: Choose Your Brief & Plan) and take it from idea to presented portfolio piece. Pick something that stretches you **by one notch, not ten**: a finished, polished piece at 80% of the dream beats an abandoned masterpiece.

BRIEF	LEANS ON	BRIEF-SPECIFIC CHECKS
Movie / event poster	Compositing + type + layer styles (M4, M5)	One dominant title, a clear hierarchy, type inside the trim; export for print (300 ppi CMYK PDF with bleed, plus a screen JPG) or for screen
Surreal photo composite	Selections, masks, match light, shadows (M4)	Shadows and light direction agree; grain and color match across elements
Portrait, fully retouched	Frequency separation, dodge & burn, grade (M2, M3)	Skin texture kept (heal, don't erase), no plastic look, dodge & burn subtle; the subject's consent
Old photo restoration	Healing, cloning, tone, color (M1, M2, M3)	Scratches and dust gone without smudged detail; tone and color balanced; the result still looks like the original era
Product hero shot	Cutout, background, light, generative (M4, M6)	A clean cutout, a believable contact shadow, a background that supports rather than competes; generative steps done at home and disclosed

BRIEF	LEANS ON	BRIEF-SPECIFIC CHECKS
Brand mini-kit (logo lockup + social set)	Shapes, type, Smart Objects, batch (M5, M6)	A logo lockup built from shapes and type; social pieces share fonts, palette, and layout via Smart Objects

Brief-specific checks are quoted from the Module 7 answer key. Learners with no suitable photos, or who arrive behind, can use the synthetic backup briefs in `labs/module-7/practice/` (an old photo to restore, or a product and backdrop for a hero shot) and the plain wall scene `l22-mockup-wall.jpg` for the mockup.

IMAGES AND CONSENT

Learners use their own photos, the kit's practice files, or images they have the right to use. The course website's example images are licensed to the author and **must not** be used. Portraits need the subject's consent to be retouched and shown. Any generative content is disclosed in the statement (and Content Credentials may travel with the file).

◆ REQUIRED DELIVERABLES

- ◆ **The plan** (Lesson 20): a one-line brief ("A [what] for [who], to be seen [where], that feels [three adjectives]"), 5–10 references, a moodboard (palette, one or two fonts, a layout sketch), and a skill map tagged by module.
- ◆ **The layered master** (Lesson 21): a clean `capstone_final.psd` with named, grouped, color-labeled layers, plus at least one earlier version (`capstone_v1.psd`).
- ◆ **The delivery file** (Lesson 22): exported for its destination (sRGB JPG or PNG for screen; a print PDF at 300 ppi with bleed to spec).
- ◆ **The presentation** (Lesson 22): the piece in at least one context mockup with a shadow, a before/after or process image, and a two-sentence artist statement.

REQUIREMENTS CHECKLIST

◆ PLAN (LESSON 20)

- ◆ One-line brief: what, who, where, three adjectives
- ◆ 5–10 references and a moodboard
- ◆ Skill map, each move tagged by module
- ◆ Document set up from the destination: size, resolution, color mode

◆ CRAFT (LESSONS 21–22 RUBRIC)

- ◆ One clear focal point that survives the squint test

◆ BUILD (LESSON 21)

- ◆ Non-destructive: adjustment layers, Smart Objects, masks
- ◆ Layers named, grouped by role, color-labeled
- ◆ Snapshots and versioned saves before risky steps
- ◆ A 100% pass for stray artifacts; clean master saved

◆ PRESENT & SHIP (LESSON 22)

- ◆ Delivery file exported correctly for its destination

- ◆ Consistent light and color across the image
- ◆ No fringe, halo, or chopped hair at 100%
- ◆ Deliberate type (if any): hierarchy, spacing, one or two fonts
- ◆ At least one context mockup with a shadow
- ◆ A before/after or process image
- ◆ A two-sentence statement: what and who, then one decision and why

GRADING RUBRIC

Rows 1–6 are the **Honest Critique** from Lesson 22, word for word: the same six rows learners self-score in the participant workbook, reviewers use on the printed rubric cards, and the answer key's reference notes describe. Rows 7–9 score the process against the Module 7 answer key's reference notes for Lessons 20, 21, and 22. Score each row 1–3. **Type (if any)** is marked N/A when the piece has no type, so the maximum is 27 (24 without type). A workbook "strong" corresponds to 2 or 3, "not yet" to 1.

Pass = no scored row below 2, plus a delivered export and a saved layered master.

ROW & QUESTION	NOT YET (1)	STRONG (2)	EXEMPLARY (3)
1 • Focal point /3 Does one thing clearly win my attention first?	Nothing wins, or two focal points compete (no step-back).	One element clearly wins attention first, and it's the one the brief intends.	The eye then moves through the piece in a deliberate order.
2 • Light & color /3 Is it consistent across the whole image? Any element that does not belong?	Elements with different light; no match or unifying grade.	Consistent light and color across the image; a unifying grade at the top of the stack.	A confident grade that expresses the brief's three adjectives.
3 • Edges & masks /3 Any fringe, halo, or chopped hair at 100%?	Halo or fringe around a cutout (the 100% pass was skipped); smears or repeats.	Clean edges and masks at 100%; no distracting artifacts.	Invisible edges even on hard cases (hair, fur, glass).
4 • Type (if any) /3 or N/A Clear hierarchy, tasteful spacing, one or two fonts?	No clear reading order, default spacing, too many fonts or effects.	Clear hierarchy, deliberate spacing, one or two fonts; type inside the trim.	Type and layout feel professionally designed and serve the brief's mood.

ROW & QUESTION	NOT YET (1)	STRONG (2)	EXEMPLARY (3)
5 • Believability /3 Do shadows agree on one light? Any telltale AI artifacts?	Shadows disagree, a missing contact shadow, or visible AI artifacts.	Shadows agree on one light; no telltale AI artifacts; generative content disclosed.	Grounded with contact and cast shadows, depth, and reflected light.
6 • The squint test /3 Blurred down, does the composition still read?	Blurred down, the layout falls apart or the room calls out the wrong focal point.	Blurred down, the composition still reads; the room names the intended focal point.	Strong, simple shapes that read instantly at any size.
7 • Plan /3 L20 • brief before brush	Brief missing a slot, no clear "done," or no skill map.	One-line brief with all four slots, 5–10 references, 3–5 palette colors, one or two fonts, a thumbnail layout, a skill map tagged by module; the piece matches it.	A well-scoped, one-notch stretch; the moodboard is clearly visible in the result.
8 • Build & file /3 L21 • a tidy file is a fast file	Flat, unnamed stack; edits painted onto the photo layer; no saved versions.	<code>capstone_final.psd</code> plus an earlier version; groups named by role and color-labeled; adjustment layers, Smart Objects, and masks.	A file you could hand to a teammate: nothing dead left behind, snapshots before risky steps.
9 • Present & ship /3 L22 • a piece, not a file	The .psd or a CMYK JPG delivered for screen; art pasted flat over a mockup; a statement that lists tools or apologizes.	A delivery file named and sized for its destination; at least one context mockup with a soft shadow; a before/after or process image; a two-sentence statement.	A polished presentation that tells the story of one real decision, and names the next grow.

COMPLETION POLICY

A learner **completes the course** when every session deliverable has been submitted and the capstone meets the pass rule: **no scored row below 2, plus a delivered export and a saved layered master**. A high total with one row at 1 does *not* pass. Below the bar, give targeted feedback tied to the rows above and allow a resubmission (the Module 7 guide suggests a finished piece emailed within a week for written feedback).

PRESENTATIONS & PEER CRITIQUE

The Session 8 protocol from the Module 7 facilitator guide: **about 4 minutes per learner**, 50 minutes for up to 11 learners. Hand out printed rubric cards (rows 1–6) to reviewers.

◆ EACH PRESENTER

- 1 **Present (90 s):** the final (in its mockup), the two-sentence statement, one process image or before/after.
- 2 **Squint test (15 s):** the whole room squints; two or three people call out what they see first.
- 3 **Presenter notes (15 s):** write the grow in the workbook's critique box and say thank you.

◆ TWO REVIEWERS (90 S), ASSIGNED IN ADVANCE

- 1 "The first thing I notice is... and what confused me was..."
- 2 Pick one rubric row: one **glow** (what works, specifically).
- 3 One **grow**, phrased "I wonder if..." or "What if you tried..."

KEEP CRITIQUE KIND AND SPECIFIC

Critique the work, not the person; point at the pixels; judge against the brief, not your taste; the presenter listens and says thank you, no defending; kind is not the same as vague. For 12 or more learners, run the same protocol in pods of 4 to 5 for 30 minutes, then a 15-minute whole-room showcase of one piece per pod. For groups under 6, give each presenter 7 to 8 minutes.

SCORING SHEET

Learner: _____ Brief: _____ Date: _____

ROW	SCORE (1-3)	NOTES
1 • Focal point		
2 • Light & color		
3 • Edges & masks		
4 • Type (if any)	☐ N/A	
5 • Believability		
6 • The squint test		
7 • Plan		
8 • Build & file		
9 • Present & ship		

ROW	SCORE (1-3)	NOTES
Total /27 (/24 if no type) · Export ☐ · Master ☐		Pass ☐ Resubmit ☐